

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

War, political

DIRECTOR

Gillo Pontecorvo

WRITERS

Gillo Pontecorvo,
Franco Solinas

STARS

Jean Martin, Brahim
Hadjadj, Yacef Saadi

BEFORE

1960 Pontecorvo's movie *Kapo* is one of the first attempts to depict the horrors of the Holocaust on screen.

AFTER

1969 Pontecorvo's *Burn!* stars Marlon Brando as a British agent who manipulates a slave revolt on a Caribbean island to pervert it in the interests of big business.

2006 Ken Loach's *The Wind that Shakes the Barley* tells the story of Republican fighters in the Irish War of Independence.

There are many ways to tackle war and political strife in fiction. Filmmakers can approach it from a humanist perspective, following civilians as the external conflict escalates around them, or follow rank-and-file soldiers as they carry out their duties, and examine the moral crises they face in doing so.

The majority of movies about conflict tend to take one of these two perspectives. *The Battle of Algiers*, however, adopts a journalistic perspective instead to follow Algeria's attempts to gain independence from the French. That is to say, it approaches the conflict forensically, its narrative following the progression of significant events. While it does have prominent figures in its narrative, particularly Ali La Pointe, one of the leaders of the Algerian resistance, it is not the story of any one individual. The movie is,



With its use of documentary-style filming techniques, the movie's large crowd scenes resemble real newsreel footage.

as the title suggests, the story of the Battle of Algiers. Director Gillo Pontecorvo's camera mimics that of a photojournalist on the streets, capturing events from an objective remove.

Minute by minute

